A Giant Rodent Lived in Thailand Long Ago

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Imagine a **rodent** the size of a dog, running through a forest 34 million years ago. Two fossil teeth from a Thai mine belonged to a new species called **Yakamys sirindhornae**.

The fossils were found at the Bang Mark Pit in the Krabi **lignite** mine. Scientists from McGill University, Thailand's Department of Mineral Resources, and French research groups studied them. All that was left was two teeth: a lower second **molar** and a lower **incisor**.

To guess its size, the team used seven ways to work out weight from tooth size. Their best guess is about 30 kilograms, about 66 pounds twice as heavy as other **rodents** of the time, including one called Hulgana.

But the guess is far from sure. Virginie Millien of McGill University called it 'only a ballpark figure.'

The name Yakamys joins 'yak,' the Thai word for giant, with 'mys,' the Greek word for mouse or rat. It honors Princess Maha Chakri Sirindhorn. Until now, giant **rodents** were thought to have grown up mostly in South America, but this find points to Southeast Asia.

Word Treasure

rodent -- A rodent is an animal with big front teeth for gnawing, like a mouse or a rat.

molar -- A molar is one of the big flat teeth at the back of the mouth that you use for chewing.

incisor -- An incisor is a sharp front tooth used for biting and cutting food.

lignite -- Lignite is a soft brown coal that forms from old plants buried in the ground.

Yakamys sirindhornae -- Yakamys sirindhornae is the name scientists gave to this giant rodent that lived long ago.

Background you need

A fossil is what is left of a living thing from long ago, like a tooth or a bone that turned to stone in the ground.

Scientists study fossils to learn what animals looked like and how they lived.

Even a single tooth can give clues about an animal's size, because bigger animals often have bigger teeth.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists from McGill University, Thailand's Department of Mineral Resources, and French research groups

WHAT: Two fossil teeth were found that belonged to a new giant rodent species called Yakamys sirindhornae

WHERE: The Bang Mark Pit in the Krabi lignite mine in Thailand

WHY: The find shows giant rodents may have grown up in Southeast Asia, not only in South America

Why it matters

Learning how scientists guess an animal's size from just two teeth shows you how to solve a big puzzle from tiny clues, just like you do in school.

Test what you remember

1. What kind of animal was Yakamys sirindhornae?

- (A) A kind of fish
- (B) A giant rodent
- (C) A big lizard
- (D) A small bird

2. What was left of Yakamys for scientists to study?

- (A) A whole skeleton
- (B) A footprint in rock
- (C) A nest
- (D) Two teeth

3. Where were the fossils found?

- (A) Under a school in France
- (B) At the Bang Mark Pit in the Krabi lignite mine
- (C) On a beach in Canada
- (D) In a cave in South America

4. About how heavy did scientists guess Yakamys was?

- (A) About 300 grams
- (B) About 30 kilograms
- (C) About 3 kilograms
- (D) About 300 kilograms

5. What does yak mean in the name Yakamys?

- (A) Mouse
- (B) Giant
- (C) Princess
- (D) Tooth

6. What did Virginie Millien say about the size guess?

- (A) It was exactly right
- (B) It was far too small
- (C) It was only a ballpark figure
- (D) It was proven by a whole skeleton

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Virginie Millien of McGill University: The size guess is only a rough estimate, a ballpark figure.

2. Scientists' earlier idea: Giant rodents were thought to have grown up mostly in South America, but this find points to Southeast Asia.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):